AI Engineering and Claude Architect · Part V, Certification

CCAR-F Study Plan

The Exam-First Route Through the Course

What to read for the exam, in what order, what to skip, and how to know when you're ready.

Exam	Claude Certified Architect – Foundations, guide v1.0, July 2026
Required reading	487 pages
Practice	287 pages: 500 questions, 3 mocks and worked exercises
Optional background	934 pages, in `09-Optional-Background`

The Exam-First Route

Key idea

Read by domain, test by domain, then take timed mocks. Spend your time in proportion to the guide's weights, and let your error log decide what to reread. Everything in the optional folder can wait until after the exam.

Study order. The pack is arranged by the guide's five domains, so its numbered folders run in a different order from the course's modules. Read Domain 4's AI03 L1 first if the Messages API is new to you, since Domains 1 and 2 use its terms.

What's required

Domain 1, 27% · `01-Domain-1-Agentic-Architecture-27pct`, 105 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI06L1-Workflows-or-Agents	16	TS 1.6
AI06L2-Agentic-Loop	18	TS 1.1
AI06L6-Multi-Agent	20	TS 1.2, 1.3, 5.3
AI06L7-Sessions-Harnesses	18	TS 1.7, 5.4
AI06L8-Hooks-Escalation	18	TS 1.4, 1.5, 5.2
AI13L2-SDK-and-CLI	15	SDK reading level, and the CLI flag sheet

Domain 2, 18% · `02-Domain-2-Tools-and-MCP-18pct`, 68 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI06L3-Tool-Design	17	TS 2.1, 2.3
AI06L4-MCP-Architecture	16	TS 2.4
AI06L5-MCP-Integration-Errors	19	TS 2.2, 2.4, 5.3
AI12L1-How-Claude-Code-Works	16	TS 2.5, built-in tools

Domain 3, 20% · `03-Domain-3-Claude-Code-20pct`, 70 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI12L2-CLAUDE-MD-Rules	16	TS 3.1, 3.3
AI12L3-Skills-Subagents-Hooks	17	TS 3.2
AI12L4-Plan-Mode-Refinement	16	TS 3.4, 3.5
AI12L5-CI-CD	21	TS 3.6, 4.6, 1.6

Domain 4, 20% · `04-Domain-4-Prompts-and-Output-20pct`, 98 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI03L1-Messages-API	19	Foundation: tool_use, stop_reason, tool_choice, history
AI03L2-Prompt-Engineering	22	TS 4.1, 4.2
AI03L3-Structured-Output	23	TS 4.3, 4.4
AI03L5-Caching-and-Batches	21	TS 4.5. For caching, know only that it exists
AI13L3-Pydantic-Resources	13	Pydantic, retries, MCP resources

Domain 5, 15% · `05-Domain-5-Context-and-Reliability-15pct`, 59 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI03L6-Context-Engineering	21	TS 5.1
AI05L4-Query-Context-Citations	18	TS 5.6. Citations and provenance sections
AI10L3-Evals	20	TS 5.5. Sampling, calibration and segments sections

Scenarios · `06-Scenarios-and-Design-Problems`, 56 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI13L4-Scenarios-Exercises	19	All six scenarios, and the guide's four exercises
AI06L9-DP-Support-Agent	17	S1 worked in depth
AI06L10-DP-Research-System	20	S3 worked in depth

Final revision · `08-Final-Revision`, 17 pages

PDF	Pages	Covers
AI13L5-Final-Revision	17	All 30 task statements, and guide vs current behavior

Skim or skip inside required lessons. The guide excludes detailed language implementation, so treat each lesson's **Java** section as optional for the exam. AI03 L5's caching detail, AI05 L4's retrieval mechanics and AI10 L3's general eval tooling go beyond the objectives, too. Those task-statement sections are what count. Certification lens sections, at the end of each lesson, tell you what's in scope.

A four-week plan

This is my suggestion, at about 1.5–2 hours a day. Adjust it to your experience. The page counts show the load, and they aren't a promise about how long you'll take.

Week	Days	Read	Practice
1	1–2	`00-Start-Here`, the guide's sections 1–6	Guide's 12 samples, untimed
1	3–7	Domain 1	Bank Q1–135, in sets of about 30
2	8–10	Domain 2	Bank Q136–225
2	11–14	Domain 3, and build guide Exercise 2	Bank Q226–325
3	15–17	Domain 4, and try guide Exercise 3	Bank Q326–425
3	18–19	Domain 5	Bank Q426–500
3	20–21	`06-Scenarios-and-Design-Problems`	Module exercises
4	22	Review the error log	**Mock 1, timed**
4	23–24	Restudy weak task statements	Official practice exam, if you have access
4	25	Review	**Mock 2, timed**
4	26–27	Restudy, `AI13-Exercises`	Retake bank misses
4	28	Final revision	**Mock 3, timed**
4	29–30	Handbook and guide, twice	Nothing new on the last day

Short on time? A two-week version: read the Certification lens and revision box of each required lesson first, along with the handbook, then use bank results to choose which full lessons to read, and keep all three mocks.

The guide's own preparation

The guide's sample questions and four exercises are the official advice. Do them, even if you do nothing else in `06`. If you can access the official practice exam, use it to find weak spots. One candidate says it reuses a pool, so a repeat score overstates readiness.

How you know you're ready

These are my own suggested signals, and the guide publishes no raw-score cutoff. No practice score can predict the result.

Signal	Target
First-attempt mock score	80% or better
Lowest domain on a mock	70% or better
Time on a mock	110 minutes or less
Error log	No distractor family keeps recurring
Flag sheet and file locations	Recalled without notes

Before you book

1. Recheck the certification page for a newer guide, on or after **November 17, 2026.** A third-party prep site reports updates on that schedule for three other exams, without naming CCAR-F. I couldn't confirm that at the source.
2. Confirm the retake policy, eligibility and delivery rules on the official pages.
3. Follow the guide if a practice item here ever disagrees with it.

What's not in this pack

→ **Real exam questions.** None was used or sought, and all the practice items here are original.

→ **Pass guarantees.** This is preparation material. It isn't affiliated with, or endorsed by, Anthropic.

→ **Runs against a live model.** Without an API key, the code that calls models has been compiled but not run. The labs that don't need a model have been run, and each module's references say which is which.

Your plan: exam date, and weak domains